kinsmen in Bengal, an imperial farman arrived for Muzaffar Khan: have the Kabuli arrested.

If the idea was to keep the visiting Qaqshal under observation, Muzaffar Khan could have interpreted the order accordingly. As Badauni tells it, however, the governor took to the task with ham-fisted and mean-spirited zeal. He rode out to arrest Roshan Beg himself; then, waving his farman in Baba Khan Qaqshal's face, ordered the respected leader of the clan to cut his kinsman's head off. At this, writes Nizamuddin, all the Qaqshals in Bengal 'trembled together, and resolved upon mutiny'.[24]

The Bengal rebellion had begun.

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News of the storm arrived in Fatehpur in late February 1580, and it is telling of how volatile Akbar's court was at this time that, by March, several of his courtiers were plotting to join the Bengalis. They were promptly executed. Back in the east, however, the revolt gathered force by the day, while Muzaffar Khan fumbled and hesitated.

Neither would the governor 'himself arrange the troops' for battle, nor let his officers do so. When, finally, he did send an army against the mutineers, the battle was a shambles. Khwaja Shamsuddin, leading the imperial troops, saw his men 'going over to the enemy from every side' and his fellow commanders deserting in a steady stream. When an officer and friend came towards the khwaja, 'I thought that he would help me,' he said, 'but the faithless . . . fellow hit me with a spear, and I fell and was nearly dead.'[25]

The leaders who remained loyal, meanwhile, were hardly serving the imperial cause any better. These were Akbar's newly recruited talent, and '[it] need hardly be said', writes Badauni's acid pen, 'that by Hakim Abu-l-Fath, who was a bottle-man rather than a battle-man, and by Patr Das, who was a Hindu writer, no great signs of valour would be likely to be shown in this line'.

Muzaffar Khan barricaded himself in the Tanda fort ('four old walls and nothing more')[26] and began to woo the rebels with belated generosity. But '[w]hat profit comes of good nature and liberality at an improper time . . .?', asks Abul Fazl wisely. The most the furious warlords would do is allow their hated governor a choice: join them, or leave for Mecca.